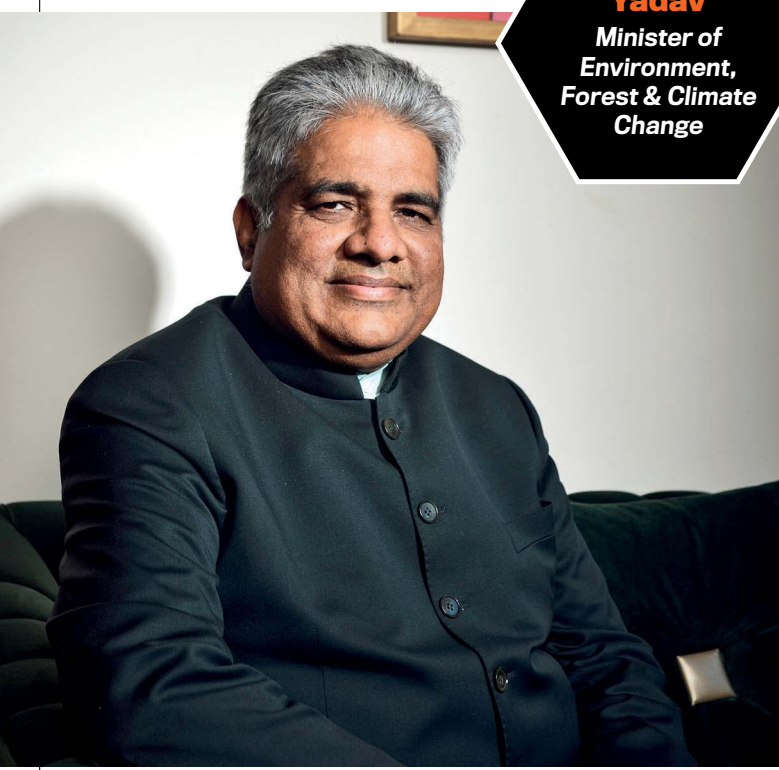
A Thinner Canopy

India has set ambitious environmental goals for itself. But achieving them will require more than just conviction

By Rahul Noronha



Bhupender Yadav
Minister of Environment, Forest & Climate Change

RAJWANT RAWAT

BOLD & BRAVE

50 PER CENT Share of electricity India aims to produce from clean fuels by 2030



20 cheetahs were brought to India from Africa—eight in September 2022 and 12 this February

BUT...

'Moderately dense forests' area dropped by **1,582** sq. km

(2019) **308,472** sq. km

(2021) **306,890** sq. km

CLIMATE CHANGE has a mental component: what people think of it can be as fickle as the weather, and as determinative. In contemporary India, the environment presents a paradox: acknowledged as vital in theory, often seen as an irritant on the path to growth in practice. The environment, forests and climate change ministry, invested with more and more significance these days, finds itself navigating that dichotomy. What the world's most populous country does to fight climate change is of interest not just nationally but internationally too. Many of its self-given goals are more than kosher, in sync with global (and Indian) needs, and the mantelpiece boasts of some showpiece trophies. There are, however, areas where it's prone to scoring self-goals.

The good news first: the National Adaptation Fund for Climate Change (NAFCC), set up in 2015 to support adaptation activities in states/UTs vulnerable to climate change, has sanctioned 39 projects so far. India has also launched valuable initiatives such as the International Solar Alliance, which has 93 member countries, and the Coalition for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure. In 2022, India, under its updated Nationally Determined Contribution (NDC), resolved to bring down the emission intensity of its GDP by 45 per cent by 2030 from 2005 levels. It also aims to meet 50 per cent of its electricity requirements from cleaner fuels by 2030, while keeping its eyes set on net-zero emissions by 2070.

India earned global attention last year for its cheetah translocation project, but the recent deaths of three adult cheetahs in captivity, brought from Africa, and three cubs born in India have cast doubts on the project's future. As for that other prized big cat, Project Tiger is one of the world's success stories—the quadrennial census reported an increase of 200 specimens (with 3,167 tigers recorded in 2022) over 2018.

But tigers are also symbolic of a much larger whole. The very sanctity of forest zones is at stake, and protecting it is a challenge for environment minister Bhupender Yadav. The State of the Forest Reports tell of a marginal rise in forest cover over 2019-21—from 21.67 per cent of the total area to 21.71 per cent—with 1,582 sq. km of 'moderately dense forests' vanishing. And changes to the Forest Conservation Act, 1980, the Indian Forest Act, 1927, and the Wildlife Protection Act, 1972—proposed so as to ease sanctions for strategically key projects—have earned widespread criticism. With rising human-animal conflict at one end and urban pollution at the other—a few Indian cities are among the world's worst-hit—it's an area in need of serious attention. ■